



Apple ceases support

Apple has announced ceasure of support for the iPhone 4 and MacBook Air 2010 on October 31. <http://dgit.in/iPh4Sprt>



XBox sales pick up

Based on estimations, Xbox One sales beat PS4 sales in the US for the third month in a row <http://dgit.in/XbxSales>

to a central host and use it to communicate, or even download games and movies. Much of this content was pirated, giving rise to what may seem like the forefather of peer-to-peer file sharing and Torrent downloads.



The very first of online friends

The formative years

In the 1990s, the world was evolving rapidly to the connected forefront. Personal computers had evolved in popularity in developed nations, and people started realising the potential that a connected world may have. Hence rose IRCs, or Internet Relay Chats, in 1988, and became popular in 1990. This was a rudimentary form of text messaging and instant communication, and not until 1997 did we see the first full-blown social medium come into being.

Six Degrees was an online platform that allowed users to create their own profiles and 'friend' others on it. This was, in the true sense, a precursor of greater days for social media. The platform was named after the 'Six Degrees of Separation' theory. Originally proposed back in 1929 by Frigyes Karinthy in light of a shrinking world, the theory suggested that everyone in this world is connected and interconnected by no more than six degrees, or individuals, in between. With the advent of social media, the theory took an even more profound meaning.

Six Degrees even allowed for creation of groups, and users could browse through each other's profiles, too. However, with a lack of proper filtering and inefficient clearing of spam, Six Degrees slowly faded out by around 2002. The first really successful social medium that is still thriving happens to be Classmates.com, founded back

in 1995. The website worked in the form of providing virtual reunions of classmates from years ago. The earliest users did not have the ability to create profiles, but people could search for each other based on information supplied regarding schooling and college years. As features and options were subsequently added, Classmates.com became one of the most successful social medium around, and reportedly has over 70 million users worldwide.

This led to a number of similar social media platforms coming into being. The America Online Limited, popularly known as AOL, has also played a crucial role in the success of social media. In hindsight, AOL had one of the most forward-thinking aspects that took the Internet forward by providing information and a medium for communication, in one place. It was among the very first to provide member-driver communities to discuss and exchange information. AOL's initiatives have continuously catered to the young internet generation by providing stories that were region- and time-agnostic, and could provide a medium for large sections of the population to relate to. This is what gave rise to blogs, and the notion of 'viral content', which would take center stage many years later.

Yahoo had set up shop by the mid 90s, and quickly went on to become the most popular search engine of its time. Yahoo had also popularised email services, and gave rise to one of the most iconic chat services of all time – Yahoo Messenger. Quirky backgrounds, an easy layout that promoted casual chatting and the idea of 'chat rooms' for group chats became popular in the early 2000s, with Yahoo at the center of it all. Regional social sites were the next to follow, with the likes of BlackPlanet.com and AsianAvenue.com.

The formative years could be noted till around 2002, when all the legendary forefathers of social media were setting up shop. From present times' perspective, these years can also be termed as the pre-Facebook era. These

are the features and platforms that laid the base for social media to become a global phenomenon. By 2000s, the race to have a personal computer at home had spread beyond developed countries, and by around 2003, many Indian households were privy to PCs and abysmally slow Internet connections. Naturally, graphic-intensive content remained impractical for the longest time, and chat-based services remained prevalent. Google slowly came out of the shadows with Orkut, Myspace was rampant at one time, Facebook was born, and LinkedIn and Twitter all amassed millions of users.

The birth of viral content

Friendster, formed in 2002, really cracked the code for a social media platform that was embraced by as many as three million users in its heyday. The site's interface resembled that of a dating site, and this relatability worked in getting users accustomed to it. The fundamentals of it lay in providing 'Circles', or common interests where users with absolute common interests could join, share, discuss and make friends. This has long been accepted as the founding principle of social media.

Although Friendster got off to a fantastic start, flawed management practices and other aspects led to its notable downfall. This was soon followed by a social medium that took an entirely



Taking a professional route to social media

different approach. LinkedIn, formed in 2003, was aimed at business users to form professional networks and business connections. This platform took a serious approach at social media, far from finding yesteryear classmates